



GDD 49

Mind & Belonging

Asking for help is the strong move.

The College mental-health node. The leap to college or work, leaving home, new independence, loneliness, academic and social pressure, is one of life's hardest transitions and a peak window for difficulty. It carries the Life-Skills Toolkit into adult stakes: managing stress and low mood, beating loneliness by building belonging, protecting body image and self-worth, and, above all, reaching for help early. High-care, healthy-coping only, warmth before everything. Seven mechanics, 29 choice-and-voice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Look after your mind. Find your people.

Mind & Belonging is the College wellbeing anchor. Leaving home is exciting and lonely and hard, and this node carries the Life-Skills Toolkit (Cool-Down, Help Map) into adult stakes: recognising stress, anxiety, low mood and homesickness; healthy coping; building belonging and beating loneliness; protecting body image and self-worth; and, above all, reaching for help early, knowing exactly where to go. It is a high-care node: only healthy coping, warmth before everything, and any sign of distress met with an immediate route to support. New v2 build, underpinning every other College node.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g49 · mind-belonging (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 6 · ages 18-22 · adult / warm / high-care
Thread / topics	C · Feelings & Life Skills · UNESCO 5.6, 5.5, 6.4
Prerequisite / builds on	g48 (Money & Independence) · builds on g39 (Bounce), g42 · pairs g52
Gating	Open · high-care mental-health node (crisis routing; healthy coping only)
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the College wellbeing anchor.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

15

myth-flips

29

choice & voice

0%

binary taps

Reaching out is strength. India faces a serious student mental-health picture, driven by academic pressure, competition, isolation far from home, and heavy stigma around seeking help, especially for young men. So this node normalises the struggle (homesickness and loneliness are common, not weakness), treats belonging as something you build, teaches only healthy coping, and dismantles the stigma, reframing early help-seeking as the strong, smart move and signposting real support every step of the way.

Leaving home, finding your feet.

From the Chapter 6 personas (18-22). First-generation and out-of-state students, hostel isolation, family expectations and a culture of stigma, met with warmth, normalisation and clear routes to help.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Deepak, 20	That homesickness and impostor feelings are normal, not failure.	strike-rewrite + branch: settling in.
Rohan, 20	That reaching out is strength, beating the men's-stigma myth.	strike-rewrite: reach out.
Every student	Healthy coping and a way to build belonging.	sort + role-play: cope & connect.
Dr. Mehta (counsellor)	Students who reach for real help early, with the right routes.	branch + match: routes & crisis.

Why this works (the evidence). Leaving home is a peak window for difficulty, so homesickness, loneliness and a bumpy start are normal and ease as routine and connection grow, and belonging is built by reaching out, joining things and saying yes. Only healthy coping is taught, routine, sleep, movement, talking, breathing, breaks, never anything using pain, restriction or shock, and impostor feelings are common and self-worth isn't grades or looks. Reaching out early is strength, you don't have to be in crisis to deserve support, and any sign of heavy low mood or self-harm thoughts is met with warmth and an immediate route, not assessment questions: Tele-MANAS 14416, KIRAN 1800-599-0019, a campus counsellor or a trusted person. This is anti-stigma signposting, never therapy.

Seven moves, led by the choice.

It's a wellbeing-skills game, so **branch** leads (choose the healthy, connecting, help-seeking move), with **strike-rewrite** clearing the stigma myths and **sort** separating healthy coping from what drains; **role-play** gives the words to connect and reach out. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE YOUNG ADULT DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (the choice) signature	Chooses the healthy, connecting or help-seeking move.	Agency in wellbeing.	19
strike-rewrite	Busts a stigma myth ("asking for help is weak").	Conceptual change.	15
sort	Sorts normal vs signal; healthy coping vs draining; kind vs harsh self-talk.	The line.	14
reflect	Internalises that struggle is normal and reaching out is strength.	Values; self-worth.	12
role-play (voice)	Starts a connection; opens up; supports a friend; reaches out.	Voice; warmth.	10
spot	Spots the healthy reset, the kind self-talk, the toolkit.	Reading the moment.	7
match	Pairs a need to a help route; a tool to a moment.	Connections.	7

29 of 84 moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it engaging?

Game feel is warmth and relief: the comfort of being told that what you're feeling is normal, the quiet win of a small connection made, and the steadying calm of a breathing space. The "oh, it's not just me" and "I'm allowed to ask for help" moments land softly and matter enormously. Sam is a warm adult peer, never clinical, and a calming breathing space is always one tap away.

Is it teaching?

Yes: recognising stress, anxiety, low mood and homesickness; using only healthy coping and the Life-Skills Toolkit; building belonging and beating loneliness; protecting body image and self-worth as an adult; and seeking help early, knowing exactly where to go, all inside a high-care, anti-stigma frame that signposts professionals and never claims to treat.

The belief it moves. From "homesickness means something's wrong with me; everyone else is fine; real men don't get help; asking for help is failing; my worth is my grades" → "the struggle is normal and shared; belonging is built; help-seeking is strength for everyone; you don't have to be in crisis to reach out; and you're far more than your grades."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the settling-in → find-your-people → cope-well → mind-and-self-worth → reach-out → tools arc, India-grounded, high-care and healthy-coping only. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Settling in	13	strike-rewrite, branch, sort	Homesickness, loneliness, the bumpy start, normalised.
Find your people	14	branch, role-play, sort	Belonging is built; reach out first; join things.
Cope well	13	sort, branch, strike-rewrite	Healthy coping only; stress and low mood.
Mind & self-worth	11	strike-rewrite, sort, branch	Impostor feelings, body image, self-compassion.
Reach out	16	strike-rewrite, branch, role-play	Help is strength; when & how; crisis support.
Tools & help	17	match, sort, reflect	Breathing space, help-finder, routes, what it is.

The 'asking for help is weak' flip + a crisis-support branch, verbatim.

```
flip: "Asking for help means I'm failing or weak."
      UN -> "Asking for help means I'm failing or weak."
      RE -> "Reaching out early is the strong, smart move; everyone needs support sometimes."

branch: A friend mentions thoughts of harming themselves.
        best -> Stay with them warmly and help them reach support now
               (Tele-MANAS 14416, a trusted adult).
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 49 Mind and Belonging — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
Homesickness and loneliness mean something's wrong with me.	They're common, normal reactions to a big change, not weakness.	Normalising.
Everyone else has settled in fine; only I'm struggling.	Most people are quietly finding it hard too.	Comparison.
Belonging just happens or it doesn't.	Belonging is built, by reaching out and showing up.	Belonging.
Powering through on no sleep, food or breaks is coping.	Real coping rests, eats, moves, connects and takes breaks.	Healthy coping.
Feeling like a fraud means I don't belong.	Impostor feelings are common and don't reflect reality; you earned your place.	Impostor syndrome.
My worth is my grades and looks.	Your worth isn't your productivity or appearance.	Self-worth.
Asking for help means I'm failing or weak.	Reaching out early is the strong, smart move.	Help is strength.
Real men don't talk about feelings or get help.	Everyone has a mind to look after; help-seeking is strength for all.	Men's stigma.

The micro-loop.

1. **Surface.** Sam (warm adult peer) surfaces a real moment, a homesick night, a lonely week, a low mood, a friend struggling.
2. **Choose.** The young adult chooses the healthy, connecting or help-seeking move (branch), or finds the words (role-play).
3. **The flip.** UN busts a stigma myth; RE writes the warm, true thing.
4. **Cope & connect.** Healthy coping, building belonging, self-compassion, and reaching out early.
5. **Tools & help.** A breathing space and help-finder; any sign of distress routes warmly to support.
6. **Sticker.** The Mind & Belonging badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **it's-normal reassurance** and the **warm reach-out**. It builds on Bounce (g39) and Life Ready (g42), carries the Cool-Down and Help Map tools, pairs with Money & Independence (g48) and Find Your Feet (g52), and underpins the wellbeing of every College node.

Warmth before everything.

- **Crisis routing first.** Any sign of self-harm or suicidal thinking is met with warmth and an immediate route to help, concern and resources, never assessment or screening questions.
- **Healthy coping only.** No strategy using pain, restriction or shock; nothing that could reinforce self-harm; only rest, connection, movement, breathing and reaching out.
- **Anti-stigma, not therapy.** It builds skills and signposts; it never claims to diagnose or treat, and points persistent or serious distress to professionals.
- **Normalising, not minimising.** Struggle is normalised and met with care; distress is always taken seriously.
- **Even-handed on stigma.** Help-seeking is reframed as strength for all genders, with particular care for the men's-stigma myth.
- **Private & expert-reviewed.** On-device and DPDP-aligned; reviewed by adolescent and young-adult mental-health specialists; the crisis-routing rate is closely watched.
- **Always-available calm.** A breathing space and calm mode are one tap away throughout.

If you or a friend are struggling (India). You're not alone, and it can get better. Tele-MANAS 14416 (free, 24/7, in many languages) · KIRAN 1800-599-0019 · a campus counsellor · or a trusted person. If there are thoughts of self-harm, reach out now and stay with each other, warmth and a real route to help, not facing it alone. This game builds skills and signposts; for anything heavy or lasting, a professional is the right next step.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. mind-belonging** — node.game === GameDone key === registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema**. type + typed payload; the **branch** wellbeing choice leads, with **strike-rewrite** clearing the stigma myths.
- **High-care is a hard requirement**. Crisis-routing-first, healthy-coping-only and anti-stigma-not-therapy are contractual; reviewed by mental-health specialists.
- **Fact-checked content**. Normalised transition difficulty, healthy-coping evidence, impostor-syndrome framing, and India routes (Tele-MANAS 14416 primary, KIRAN 1800-599-0019, campus counsellors) verified this build.
- **Scorecard-gated**. Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, top mechanic at 23%, 0% binary, 29 autonomy, 15 UN→RE, 6 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run score_gdd.py on any edit.
- **Help-resource hook**. Distress routes via the shared "get help" component (Tele-MANAS 14416 / KIRAN / counsellor / trusted person).
- **Tracked**. build_gate.py finalize advances g49 to v2 PASS only after order, read, score, audit and artifact gates pass.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): crisis routing first; healthy coping only; anti-stigma, not therapy; warmth before everything; even-handed on stigma; private & expert-reviewed; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Normalising lifts the weight.** Because the transition is a peak window for difficulty and almost everyone struggles, telling young people that homesickness and loneliness are normal, not weakness, directly eases shame and isolation.
- **Belonging and healthy coping are skills.** Since belonging is built and only healthy coping truly helps, teaching how to reach out, connect and cope, while never modelling anything harmful, builds real resilience.
- **Early help-seeking saves outcomes.** Because stigma, especially around young men, keeps people from care, reframing early help-seeking as strength and routing distress warmly to real support (Tele-MANAS 14416) is the most protective thing this node does.

Sources: WHO on adolescent and young-adult mental health (coping, help-seeking, stigma); transition and student-wellbeing research; healthy-coping and self-compassion evidence (links Body Confident, g21); India's Tele-MANAS 14416 (the primary national 24/7 line, with KIRAN 1800-599-0019 being integrated into it) and the Manodarpan student-wellbeing initiative; expanding campus counselling. High-care, healthy-coping only, anti-stigma and not a substitute for professional care. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 49 games now v2. Next by order: Equal & Confident (g50).